

respective modules and are exposed to hands-on projects—to learn the functional aspects of business design and adopt best practices in the ERP package,” says Krishna Kumar Tirumalai S, Head, SAP Delivery, Wipro Infotech Ltd.

For in-depth and hands on expertise, companies also conduct training programs addressing specific roles in ERP. “We have a career development framework, through which specific training is delivered to the candidate depending on the job experience the candidate has acquired over the years and on his or her aspiration and capability,” says Suman K Mazumder, Director, Application Services Global Delivery, IBM India.

This training period varies depending upon the role of the individual and the organisation. On-the-job training is also common in many organisations, and some are flexible enough to allow and encourage employees to pursue education related to their job function.

“ERP consultants need to keep themselves updated with new applications and evolving technologies. Quitting their official obligations and pursuing full-time study is not a wise choice. The concept of part-time module courses has therefore evolved—to help them keep pace with changing trends,” says Anand Ekambaram, Director, Education Services, SAP India Ltd.

The Options

Careers for ERP professionals lie in product development, implementation, maintenance, and consulting. Within these, there are multiple options available. Industry verticals often refer an ERP professional as a consultant based on his or her role and area of expertise in that organisation. The ERP employment scenario offers career options that can be classified primarily into Functional, Technical, and Training.

The Functional Area: Career options here need in-depth understanding along with experience of physical implementation in various functions of the business process. “By relevant experience and sound knowledge of functions like finance, human resources, materials management, quality control, production planning, manufacturing processes, etc., a person can excel in an ERP career. Also, the full life-cycle experience of the implementation of the ERP package in one or more functional modules is necessary,” says B Chandrashekhar, Vice President and Delivery Head (SAP, Oracle and Siebel), Datamatics Limited, a company that provides off-shore outsourcing software services.

The ERP functional consultant interacts with the client organisation—he understands their business processes, requirements, and problems. He then analyses and builds the process flow of the functions, and recommends a cost-effective implementation of an ERP solution package.

The Technical Area: In ERP software companies, the individual can be involved in development of various applications on different platforms—an ERP package or specific modules within a package. They work on ERP applications like mySAP, Oracle 11i, PeopleSoft, and J D Edwards, to name a few. These professionals—often referred to as consultants—code the requirements of the business and integrate them to form

a plan for implementation of ERP in the clients’ business process models. In organisations that provide consulting services, the technical professionals are also required for the implementation team and maintenance.

The Training Area: After relevant industry experience and pursuing training through vendor-specific courses, training can be a good career option. Organisations looking to train their freshly-recruited ERP staff always need training professionals. Experience of working on different platforms and knowledge of many domains are important for a trainer.

Freelancing: Many ERP professionals provide freelance consulting to client organisations. It is mostly small or medium businesses who hire freelance consultants for implementation or maintenance for their ERP requirements. As a freelancer, one can perform any role from the bottom to the top level, depending, of course, upon the years of experience and specialisation.

The Growth Path

Since ERP systems are implemented across different industry verticals, different designations are awarded to individuals in the ERP stream. See box *The Growth Path*.

One cannot become, say, a principal consultant in a short time-span. It takes years of experience in domains such as telecom, automotives, textiles, chemicals, etc. We can roughly say that the average time taken to climb each step of the designation ladder from the bottom is at least two years. To climb up to the position of Principal Consultant takes at least eight to 12 years with industry experience in particular domain.

It is difficult to determine the approximate salary range. The remuneration structure differs widely amongst companies, based on their size and policies. However, one can expect Rs 30,000 per month to Rs 45,000 and higher at the lower levels, that is, when advancing from Trainee Consultant / Trainee Software Engineer to Assistant Consultant / Software Engineer.

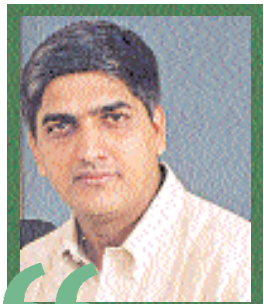
From Associate Consultant/Senior Software Engineer to Senior Consultant / Senior Software Consultant, one expects between Rs 45,000 and 65,000. From Lead Consultant / Lead Software Consultant to Principal Consultant / Senior Technical Advisor, between Rs 65,000 and 80,000 can be expected. As for the top-most designations in both the functional and technical areas, Rs 85,000 per month and above is a norm. However, these figures are indicative.

Concluding Remarks

A lot of Indian companies have come out with highly customisable ERP package suites specifically for small and medium enterprises in various domains. These have a product life-cycle, and need to be constantly upgraded to keep pace with the technology and business requirements. Opportunities in such organisations are very healthy, both in India and abroad.

A self-assessment of one’s strengths and areas of interest must be clearly conducted before opting for this field as a career. Once that’s done, the world awaits you! ■

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“Since ERP solves a business problem with technology, it is important to have a good understanding of either technology or domain, along with an appreciation of the other”

Murali Subramanian
Vice President -
Applications
Development,
Oracle India Pvt. Ltd